RAVIOLI WITH TALEGGIO FONDUTA, PEAS, AND SPECK

SERVES	TOTAL TIME
4-6	**3 h plus the dough rest**

INGREDIENTS

1 batch	Egg dough
474 g	Heavy cream
340 g	Taleggio with rind
10 g	Egg yolk
150 g	English peas, shelled
42 g	Olive oil
5 g	Garlic, thinly sliced
60 g	Unsalted butter, cold and cubed
85 g	Speck, finely diced
20 g	Pea tendrils, tender
22 g	Parmigiano-reggiano, finely grated
quantity not given	Salt
quantity not given	Black pepper

METHOD

1. For the filling, bring the cream to a bare simmer in a saucepan over medium heat. Drop the heat to low and hold it there until the cream has reduced by a third, 1 to 1½ hours. Watch the bottom of the pan, it scorches easily. Let it stand 5 minutes.
2. While the cream reduces, cut the rind off the Taleggio and keep only the creamy interior. Chop that into 1-inch pieces.
3. Pour the cream into a high-speed blender. With it running on low to medium, feed the cheese in slowly until the mixture emulsifies. Taste before you salt, because Taleggio brings plenty of salinity on its own.
4. Still blending, add the egg yolk. Cover and refrigerate at least 1 hour. Filling that has sat several hours or overnight needs 30 minutes out of the fridge to soften before you pipe it.
5. Make 35 to 40 ravioli with the egg dough and the fonduta.
6. Salt a small pot of water heavily and bring it to the boil over high heat. Set up a salted ice bath with a colander standing in it.
7. Blanch the peas 20 to 30 seconds, until barely tender and still bright green. Move them into the ice bath with a slotted spoon to stop them cooking, then lift the colander out and set it aside.
8. Salt a large pot of water heavily and bring it to the boil over high heat.
9. Set a large saute pan over low heat with the oil. Add the garlic and give it 10 to 15 seconds, until it smells but takes no color. Stir the peas through and set the pan aside.
10. Slide the ravioli into the large pot and pull the heat back to a gentle simmer. A rolling boil breaks this filling. Cook 2 to 3 minutes. The thickest closure should give tenderly, and a ravioli cut open should run.
11. Meanwhile return the pea pan to medium-low heat. Drop the butter in with 115 to 170 g of pasta water, 2 to 3 ladles, and swirl to emulsify. Stir half the speck through.
12. Lift the ravioli across with a spider, raise the heat to medium and swirl 30 seconds to a minute, turning them with a spoon so both faces take the sauce. A splash more pasta water loosens it if it tightens.
13. Drop in half the pea tendrils and let them wilt in the pan, 10 to 15 seconds.
14. Divide onto plates and finish with the rest of the speck and tendrils, the parmigiano and pepper to taste.

NOTES

This fonduta is cheese and cream with a little yolk, no wine, which is what gives it the loose texture that runs out of the pasta.
Only the creamy interior of the Taleggio goes into the blender. Cut the rind away and discard it.
Reducing the cream by a third takes 1 to 1½ hours on low on purpose. A scorched pan bottom carries straight through into the filling.
The peas get 20 to 30 seconds and a salted ice bath. Longer and they lose both color and bite.
Half the speck and half the tendrils cook into the sauce, the other half go on raw at the plate.

FILLING

Taleggio Fonduta Filling

INGREDIENTS

474 g	Heavy cream
340 g	Taleggio with rind
10 g	Egg yolk
quantity not given	Salt

METHOD

1. Bring the cream to a bare simmer in a saucepan over medium heat.
2. Drop the heat to low and hold it there until the cream has reduced by a third, 1 to 1½ hours. Watch the bottom of the pan, it scorches easily.
3. Let the cream stand 5 minutes.
4. While the cream reduces, cut the rind off the Taleggio and keep only the creamy interior. Chop it into 1-inch pieces.
5. Pour the cream into a high-speed blender. With it running on low to medium, feed the cheese in slowly until the mixture emulsifies. Taste before you salt, because Taleggio brings plenty of salinity on its own.
6. Still blending, add the egg yolk.
7. Cover and refrigerate at least 1 hour before piping.

NOTES

Cream and cheese with a little yolk, no wine. The cream is there to lengthen the cheese, which is what makes the texture loose enough to ooze.
Only the creamy interior goes in. Cut the rind away and discard it.
Filling held several hours or overnight needs 30 minutes out of the refrigerator before it will pipe.
The same method works with other cheeses, which is the point of treating fonduta as a technique rather than a single recipe.
340 g of Taleggio against 474 g of cream fills 35 to 40 ravioli.

SHAPE

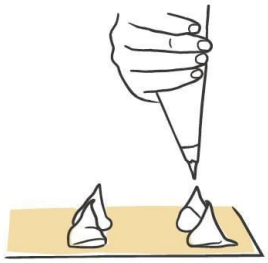
Ravioli

Region: All of Italy, north to south, and worldwide / Rest: 45 minutes to 1 hour uncovered in the refrigerator

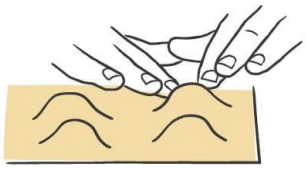
METHOD

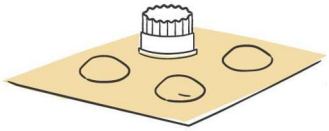
1. Make your chosen egg-based dough, then roll and sheet it.
2. Dust a wooden board with 00 flour. Cover a sheet pan with parchment, then dust the parchment with semolina.
3. Trim the sheets to 18-inch lengths with a knife and cut away the ragged edges. Save the scraps for soup. Keep the sheets under plastic wrap or a towel.
4. Lay one sheet on the board. Using a pastry bag cut to a 1-inch opening, pipe mounds of filling roughly 1 1/2 inches across and 1/2 inch high in an even run down the sheet, leaving about 2 inches between mounds.
5. If the dough feels dry rather than moderately tacky, mist it with a spray bottle held 8 to 10 inches above the board so the second sheet will stick. Skip this if the dough is already tacky.
6. Lay a second sheet gently over the first, edges lined up and no wrinkles.
7. Press around each mound with your two index fingers to expel the air pockets. For insurance, flip a #30 (1 1/8-inch) plain round cutter to its dull side and press gently over each mound to expel the last of the air.
8. For square ravioli, cut 2 1/2-inch squares with a fluted pastry cutter or fluted dough divider. A 2 1/2-inch fluted square cutter does the same thing.
9. For round ravioli, use a #60 (2 3/8-inch) plain round cutter. Press straight down with your palm flat on top of the cutter, then twist it clockwise under that pressure to finish the cut.
10. Lift the sheets from one end to peel away the surrounding scrap. Discard it or save it for soup.
11. Set the pieces on the prepared pan in a single layer and dust the pan again with semolina.
12. Repeat with the remaining sheets.
13. Refrigerate uncovered for 45 minutes to 1 hour to dry. Covered pieces sweat and get too wet. To hold longer, lay plastic wrap loosely over the pan and refrigerate up to 8 hours.

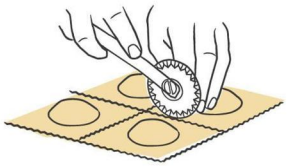
SHAPING

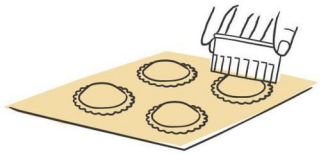

1

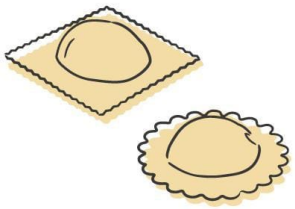

2


3


4


5


6


7

NOTES

Two-sheet construction from 18-inch sheets. The filling goes on the bottom sheet and a second sheet covers it.
Filling per piece: a mound 1 1/2 inches across and 1/2 inch high, piped through a 1-inch opening.
Spacing: mounds 2 inches apart. The cut is either a 2 1/2-inch square or a 2 3/8-inch round.
Cutters: #30 (1 1/8-inch) plain round cutter used dull side down to expel air, then either a fluted cutter or divider for 2 1/2-inch squares, or a #60 (2 3/8-inch) plain round cutter for rounds.
Cutting technique for rounds: press with a flat palm, then rotate clockwise under pressure so the cut goes all the way through.
Air is expelled twice before cutting, first with two index fingers and then with the dull cutter.
The author's restaurant version is round, roughly 2 inches across, with a ruffled edge. The square version is the red-sauce shape.
Storage: 45 minutes to 1 hour uncovered to dry, then up to 8 hours refrigerated under loose plastic.
Red sauce is the default finish. Otherwise the shape is a test bed for any filling.

DOUGH

Egg Dough

Makes: 954 g / Active Time: 8-10 min kneading / Rest: 30 min minimum, wrapped

INGREDIENTS

500 g	Tipo 00 flour
454 g	Egg yolks
as needed	Extra 00 flour for kneading
up to 1 tbsp, only if dry	Room-temperature water

METHOD

1. Mix the yolks lightly, without beating them.
2. Mound the flour on a wooden surface and open a well 5 to 6 inches across. Wider than that and the walls collapse.
3. Add half the yolks, drawing in flour from the inner wall with a fork, working round the circumference.
4. Add the rest the same way. If the wall breaks, scrape the escape back into the flour until the mass holds itself.
5. Knead 8 to 10 minutes: press down and away with the heel of your hand, rotate 180 degrees, fold, repeat. Scrape your hands and the board as you go.
6. Add water a tablespoon at a time only if it stays dry and refuses to come together.
7. Stop when it is smooth, firm, and springs back slightly when poked. The texture to aim for is Play-Doh.
8. Wrap and rest at least 30 minutes before rolling.

NOTES

454 g of yolks is roughly 24 to 26 eggs, so plan what the whites are for.
Yolks only, no whites and no whole eggs, which is what makes this rich and tender rather than elastic.
Dry winter air is the usual reason it will not come together. Flour the board sparingly, since excess dries it out.
Keeps 24 hours. Chilled overnight, pull it out 20 minutes before rolling.